A PRIVATE BRIEFING, EL PASO, THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 5, 2026

Six months of free decisions.

What to automate, what to buy, and what to leave alone before the new center opens.

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WHERE YOU ARE

The MRI is signed. No staff hired, no systems chosen.

Today

Every operational decision is cheap and reversible.

2027-01-01

Federal prior authorization APIs go live at the payers.

~2027-03

The build starts, so prior authorization is working before you open.

~2027-06

Target opening for your new center, April at the earliest. Whatever is in the vendor contracts by then is what you live with.

The 2027 rule: payers must answer prior authorization electronically, through an API, fast. Medicare Advantage, Medicaid, CHIP, exchange plans. Not TRICARE or VA.
Greenfield is the entire argument. Nothing on the slides that follow is possible to do this cheaply after opening.

CMS-0057-F, 89 FR 8758, compliance dates verified in the Federal Register rule text.

THE FREE MOVE

Put four things in every vendor contract before you sign. They cost nothing today.

- **API access** to your own data, named in the contract, not "available on request."
- **HL7 interface count and fee schedule** fixed at signature, not quoted per interface later.
- **Data export rights** in standard formats, on demand, at no charge.
- **DICOM query permissions** (worklist, query/retrieve, DICOMweb) for systems you authorize.

Before signature these are contract terms. After signature they are hostage terms.

THE HEADLINE NUMBER

11.5%

of 4.1 million denied prior authorizations were appealed (Medicare Advantage, 2024)

80.7%

of those appeals were partially or fully overturned (KFF)

Four in five appeals win. Almost nobody files one.

Every denial nobody appeals is revenue left on the table. Next: how an agent gets it back.

Source: KFF, "Medicare Advantage Insurers Made Nearly 53 Million Prior Authorization Determinations in 2024," 2026-01-28, analyzing data insurers report to CMS. Medicare Advantage, all services; CMS does not report prior authorization data by service type.

WHY GREENFIELD MATTERS

40%

of 1,000 physicians surveyed (AMA, 2025) report having staff who work **exclusively** on prior authorization.

You have not hired that person yet.

Source: American Medical Association, 2025 AMA Prior Authorization Physician Survey, 1,000 practicing physicians (400 primary care, 600 specialists). Self-reported survey data.

BEFORE THE NUMBERS: WHAT AN AI AGENT IS

Two kinds of AI agent. One works the queue in the background. One you talk to.

Workflow agent

- Works the queue in the background, inside your systems.
- A person on your staff approves every submission before it goes out.

EXAMPLE Prior authorization: it builds the request, your staff member approves it, then it goes to the payer.

Owner's agent

- Text it or call it.
- It answers from your own numbers, never from memory.

EXAMPLE "How many MRIs did we read last week, and how many slots went empty?"

Guardrails: a person signs anything clinical or outbound; numbers are calculated and checked, never guessed; HIPAA agreements with every vendor; patient data stays in the United States.

PART ONE

The thing you did not ask about.

Prior authorization and eligibility verification. Scheduling, phones, and records are real costs. This one is larger, and it is the one with the best evidence.

WHAT PRIOR AUTH COSTS YOU

13

hours a week per physician on prior authorization (AMA 2025, 1,000 physicians surveyed). Each request worked by hand.

95%

of 17,913 MRI requests approved anyway (one institution, four years).

A process that approves 95% of what it touches is one you automate, not one you staff.

Sources: American Medical Association, 2025 AMA Prior Authorization Physician Survey; self-reported. Harrer S et al., J Am Acad Orthop Surg, 2025 Feb 15;33(4):e244-e252, PMID 39729599; single institution, outpatient MRI, 2019 through 2022.

WHY NOBODY APPEALS

52%

of physicians surveyed (AMA 2025, 1,000 physicians) who do not appeal cite staff time.

59%

of the same 1,000 do not expect to win.

Both are what an agent removes.

Source: American Medical Association, 2025 AMA Prior Authorization Physician Survey; self-reported.

THE DATES LAND ON YOUR OPENING

2026-01-01

Payers must decide prior authorizations in **7 calendar days** standard, **72 hours** expedited, and publish their metrics.

2027-01-01

Payers (Medicare Advantage, Medicaid, CHIP and exchange plans) must operate a **FHIR Prior Authorization API**, plus Patient Access, Provider Access, and Payer-to-Payer APIs.

Target ~2027-06

Your new center opens into the new regime, with prior authorization already working and no legacy process to unwind.

Who the rule reaches: Medicare Advantage, Medicaid, CHIP and exchange plans. Not employer-sponsored plans, TRICARE, or VA. The payers who move first set the standard the rest follow.

Almost 63% of the medical plans surveyed in the 2025 CAQH Index report they are already building a FHIR prior authorization API ahead of the deadline.

Sources: CMS-0057-F, 89 FR 8758, compliance dates verified in rule text; covers Medicare Advantage, Medicaid and CHIP, and federally facilitated exchange plans. 63% figure: 2025 CAQH Index (DataSpring), 2026-02-19, payer self-report.

ONE ORDER THROUGH PRIOR AUTHORIZATION

An MRI order arrives at 9:00 on a Tuesday. Here is what the agent does with it.

1. The order comes in from the referring office and lands in your RIS.
2. The agent checks the patient's coverage and whether this payer requires authorization for this study.
3. If it does, the agent assembles the request from the order and the clinical notes, and checks it against that payer's rules.
4. Your staff member reviews it and approves. Only then does it go to the payer, over the payer's electronic connection.
5. The agent watches the payer's decision clock and puts the approval on the schedule the moment it arrives.
6. If it is denied, the agent drafts the appeal with the reasons and puts it in front of a person. Nothing goes out unsigned.

You will click through this yourself: a working prior authorization demo on synthetic data, no real patients, already built. The real one is wired to your RIS and payers in Phase 4.

rfinlay.github.io/imaging-priorauth-demo

Scan to follow along

PART TWO

The three things you did ask about, corrected.

Scheduling. Answering patients. Requesting records. All three are real. Two of them are not what they look like.

SCHEDULING: THE EMPTY SLOT IS NOT A NO-SHOW

Build, small
A ranked waitlist on top of the RIS fills cancelled slots.

22.3%

of 19,262 outpatient radiology exams at one center were cancelled

2.0%

of the same 19,262 exams were no-shows

70.2% of those cancellations were patient-initiated, which means most empty slots are known in advance. That is a backfill problem, not a reminder problem. **The fix: a ranked waitlist on top of the RIS that fills the cancelled slot.**

Source: Aijaz A et al., "Sociodemographic Factors Associated with Outpatient Radiology No-shows Versus Cancellations," Acad Radiol, 2024 Aug;31(8):3406-3414, PMID 38705764. University of California, Irvine. 19,262 exams, 9,713 patients. Single center.

Buy
Your RIS does this.

5.1%

of 6,989 MRI patients in a randomized trial were no-shows with phone reminders alone

3.8%

of the same patients were no-shows after adding a text message reminder

A real effect, 1.3 percentage points, in a randomized trial of 6,989 MRI patients. It did not improve arrival punctuality. **Your RIS will do this.**

Let it.

Source: Liu C et al., "Text Message Reminders Reduce Outpatient Radiology No-Shows But Do Not Improve Arrival Punctuality," J Am Coll Radiol, 2017 Aug;14(8):1049-1054, PMID 28583321. Massachusetts General Hospital. p = 0.02; only 67.5% of the texting arm could be reached by text.

ANSWERING PATIENTS: BUY IT, DO NOT BUILD IT

Buy, I integrate
A vendor answers the phone; I supervise it.

26.5%

of El Paso County residents aged 5 and over (215,186 of 813,194) speak English less than "very well." 97.8% of those 215,186 speak Spanish.

My recommendation: buy a healthcare voice vendor. I will write the specification, run the evaluation, and integrate and supervise it. The riskiest thing to get wrong: a chest-pain call, or Spanish the system garbles. And it is a funded category I cannot beat on cost.

Source: American Community Survey 2024 5-year, Table B16004, El Paso County, population 5 and over of 813,194; 215,186 speak English less than "very well." Computed from raw ACS counts via Census Reporter.

RECORDS: TWO DIRECTIONS, TWO BUILDS

Build, two small tools

Requests coming in run on a clock. Priors going out have no electronic link. I automate our side of both.

Requests coming in

The clock: HIPAA 30 days. Texas 15 business days. We design to 15.

THE FIX

- Intake and an identity check.
- Deadline alerts and the fee calculation.
- DICOM export of the study.

Priors going out

The gap: no electronic link to most facilities today. Discs still arrive by courier.

THE FIX

- The agent generates the request packet and a QR-coded envelope label.
- Tracks each request and its days outstanding.
- Disc comes back: staff scan the QR, the images route to the right patient, the radiologist is notified.

The exchange between facilities is still manual nationwide. I automate everything on our side of it.

Sources: 45 CFR 164.524 (right of access, deadlines, fee components; search and retrieval labor is not chargeable); Texas Health and Safety Code 181.102 (15 business days, electronic records); RSNA comment letter to ASTP/ONC, March 2026 (DICOM exchange is not yet a TEFCA requirement).

THE FIFTH CANDIDATE: THE NUMBERS THE OWNER ACTUALLY LOOKS AT

One system, two views. All three of you see both.

Operations

ALL THREE OWNERS

- Studies by modality. Turnaround.
- No-shows and open slots.
- Authorizations waiting, appeals in flight.
- Scanner uptime.
- Staff hours and running costs against budget.

Business health

ALL THREE OWNERS; OWNED BY THE PRACTICE

- Collections.
- Denials, and appeals won.
- Revenue by payer.

Ask it a question on Monday morning; it answers from your own numbers.

THE SCORECARD

CANDIDATE	MY RECOMMENDATION	WHAT IT DOES
Prior authorization and eligibility	**Build**	Spots the orders that need authorization, checks coverage, assembles the packet, submits through the payer's API or EDI, watches the decision clock, drafts the appeal. A person approves every submission.
Scheduling: reminders and self-scheduling	**Buy (your RIS)**	Text and call reminders, online booking, intake forms. Your RIS's own feature.
Scheduling: cancellation backfill	**Build, small**	When a slot opens, offers it by text to a ranked waitlist, inside the per-patient message cap, and books the first yes.
Answering patients (voice)	**Buy, I integrate**	A vendor answers and routes patient calls in English and Spanish. I connect it to the schedule and supervise it.
Records: inbound requests	**Build, small**	Intake, an identity check step, the statutory deadline clock (15 business days in Texas), fee calculation, status, DICOM export of the study.
Records: outbound priors	**Build, small**	Tracks requests to other facilities, follows up, imports what arrives, flags the radiologist when a prior is still missing.
Owner reporting	**Build**	Two views of one system. Operations, scanner uptime and costs against budget for the owners; collections, denials and revenue by payer for the practice. An agent you ask questions of in plain words.
Billing, claims, and the eligibility feed	**Buy**	The clearinghouse and the claims work, on your billing vendor's system. I evaluate reachability and contract terms. Row 1 reads the eligibility feed; it does not replace the vendor.

> Software intended "for administrative support of a health care facility, including the processing and maintenance of financial records, claims or billing information, appointment schedules, business analytics, information about patient populations, admissions, practice and inventory management, ... determination of health benefit eligibility, population health management, and laboratory workflow" is not a medical device.

Every candidate on the scorecard is on that list by name. The agents stop at the clinical boundary: nothing interprets an image, selects a protocol, or recommends a study.

Source: 21 U.S.C. 360j(o)(1)(A), read verbatim at Cornell Legal Information Institute. 360j(o)(2) further provides that FDA "shall not regulate" excluded administrative functions even when they coexist with device functions.

Texas SB 1188

Electronic health records with Texas patient data must be physically stored in the United States as of 2026-01-01. Every component, including the model provider, gets verified for US residency before anything is promised.

TCPA, wireless healthcare exemption

One message per day, three per week, per patient. No billing or financial content. Provider name and opt-out in every message. $500 per violation, up to $1,500 if willful.

The AI vendor's BAA

Anthropic's agreement now covers Skills, Web Search, Memory, and the Bash and Text Editor tools. It still excludes Computer Use and Web Fetch, which are exactly what you would reach for to drive a payer portal with no API. So the prior auth design routes through APIs, EDI, or a human step. Not screen-driving.

Texas HB 300

Texas privacy law covers me directly, not just through our contract. If I mishandle your patients' data, I'm the one the state comes after. That's how it should be.

Sources: Texas SB 1188 (89R), signed 2025-06-20, effective 2025-09-01, bill history at capitol.texas.gov; 47 CFR 64.1200(a)(9)(iv) and 47 U.S.C. 227; Anthropic BAA documentation at privacy.claude.com, accessed 2026-10-01; Texas Health and Safety Code Chapter 181.

THE QUESTION YOU ARE GOING TO ASK

What happens when I get hit by a bus?

- **You own the specification.** It is written for a competent engineer who has never met me, and it is the deliverable of the design engagement whether or not I build anything.
- **You own the code.** Everything specific to this center lives in a repository under your organization's account, with my access revocable by you. What you are buying is a scope of work: a design for one imaging center that can be put anywhere. Who owns any product pieces is settled in the contract, and you are never hostage to me.
- **Runbooks, not memory.** Every operational procedure is written down: how it runs, how it fails, who to call at each vendor.
- **No proprietary runtime.** Standard interfaces (HL7 v2, DICOM, payer APIs) and a named model vendor under its own BAA. Any integrator can take it over.
- **Buy where buying is right.** The voice vendor and the RIS are yours directly. Nothing routes through me that does not have to.

THE MOST IMPORTANT SLIDE

What I recommend you do not buy from me.

- **A custom voice agent.** Buy a vendor. I will specify, evaluate, and integrate it, and I will tell you when it is not good enough in Spanish.
- **Reminders, self-scheduling, and intake forms.** Your RIS does this. Make sure the contract says so, then use it.
- **Anything built to resell to other centers.** This center is the reference implementation and the priority. If I ever take on a second site, your service terms do not change, in writing.
- **Anything that touches the image clinically.** Not from me, not from anyone, without an FDA pathway.

IF IT WERE MY MONEY

I would do three things before signing another vendor contract.

- Put the four access terms into every contract this month. It is free.
- Decide now whether the prior authorization desk is a hire or a system. That decision expires the day you hire for it.
- Tell me what front desk and prior authorization actually cost you last time. Your number beats any benchmark I could bring.

THANK YOU

Every one of these decisions is reversible today. None of them will be in six months.

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APPENDIX

Reference, only if asked.

Nothing here is part of the pitch. It is what stands behind the slides if the room wants to go one level deeper, today or another day.

In this appendix: the systems to select in Phase 2, with a starting shortlist; radiology report assistance; RadAssist, the proof in daily use; what the dates depend on.

SYSTEMS TO SELECT IN PHASE 2: STARTING SHORTLIST

A starting shortlist, not a decision. The final pick is Phase 2, with your radiologists in the demos.

SYSTEM	STARTING SHORTLIST	WHAT DECIDES IT
RIS and PACS	Evaluated both ways: one bundled cloud system, or separate best-of-breed RIS plus PACS. Bundled candidates built for independent centers: Konica Minolta Exa PACS|RIS, RamSoft OmegaAI, Novarad, Intelerad. The hospital-sized award winners (Sectra, Agfa) are built for a different buyer; a premium viewer with a separate RIS only if the radiologists insist.	A reading demo with your radiologists on MRI and CT cases; five-year cost with interfaces, storage and dictation; front desk to claim in one workflow; hosting and security (BAA, SOC 2, backup, uptime); export and API terms; two or three single-site references; a timeline before June.
Dictation	The radiologists choose the tool, you choose the contract: the RIS's built-in dictation, PowerScribe One (Microsoft), Fluency for Imaging (Jacobian; 2026 Best in KLAS), Rad AI. A contracted group may already carry a license.	What your radiologists already use; the interface fee for the link to the RIS and PACS; per-radiologist cost at one to three readers.
Billing and clearinghouse	Outsource billing to an imaging-specialized firm at opening, short contract, clearinghouse and data in your name. Clearinghouses in common use: Waystar, Availity, TriZetto, Office Ally, Quadax (2026 Best in KLAS). A documented second path.	Three quotes; TRICARE, Medicare and Medicare Advantage handling; eligibility and authorization transactions reachable by the Phase 4 build; handover terms.
Also selected in Phase 2	Scheduling and reminders (inside the RIS); prior authorization and eligibility connections; patient phones, IVR and AI answering (patient-facing, separate from dictation); modality integration and worklist; reading workstations; image sharing (CD and cloud). Each carries the four contract terms from slide 3; interface fees fixed up front. Every system is scored on how easily it connects to the rest, and the integration terms go into the contract.	

Likely RIS and PACS: Exa. Negotiate as three centers for volume pricing, and put the four access terms (API, HL7 fee schedule, export, DICOM) into the Exa contract. The final pick is still Phase 2.

Basis: 2026 Best in KLAS awards (klasresearch.com, Feb 2026); vendor documentation for Konica Minolta, RamSoft, Microsoft PowerScribe One, Jacobian; no vendor on this slide has been evaluated or quoted. Fit and pricing are confirmed in Phase 2.

APPENDIX: RADIOLOGY REPORT ASSISTANCE, THE TWO DIRECTIONS

The agent drafts. The radiologist signs. Nothing clinical leaves without a human signature.

The report: RadAssist, today

Dr. Ramos uses it daily. Calcium scoring reads the scanner's numbers from a screen capture; thyroid, spine MRI, and CT spine build the report from his own template, one dropdown per sentence, with his rules for the impression. He confirms every value before it applies and signs. At your center the path has a name: DICOM worklist and query for the study, HL7 v2 ORU to carry the signed report into the RIS.

The records: a different build

Requesting records runs the other way: DICOM query and retrieve where a facility grants it, a request out and DICOM import where it does not, and the payer Provider Access API in 2027 for the claims record, in-network only, no images.

Which did you mean?

Two different builds, specified separately. I would rather ask than guess.

Across centers: one environment, isolated instances. Never one shared database.

One specification, reused for every center. The default is the industry standard, security first: one environment under one contract, and each organization in its own isolated instance, with its own database and encryption keys, its own credentials and role-based access, and its own audit log. No organization sees another's data. One owner or one joint venture: that is the whole answer. Separately owned centers that want fully separate hosting: a fully separate stack each, at higher cost. Either works.

APPENDIX: THE PROOF

Proof: RadAssist, in daily use.

Structured radiology reporting, in production and in daily use by the radiologist sitting at this table. His template, his rules, his signature. It drafts; he signs. Nothing you type leaves the browser.

Calcium scoring

Reads the scanner's numbers from a pasted screen capture. He confirms every value before it applies.

Thyroid ultrasound

ACR TI-RADS, with his follow-up rules built in.

Spine MRI, new

Cervical, thoracic, and lumbar. Built from Dr. Ramos's own template and rules. Every rule in it is his.

CT Spine, live Nov 2

The same tool, switched to CT: bony canal, calcification, the CT disc findings. Built from his sample reports two days after the MRI module.

Next, at his request: voice dictation, brain, cardiac CTA (CAD-RADS). Reading the images themselves is a future item with a regulatory path, not a promise.

radassist.app · Not a device: it formats what the radiologist graded. It never reads the image. At your center, the signed report flows into the RIS over HL7 v2 ORU, a contract term from slide 3.

APPENDIX: WHAT THE DATES DEPEND ON

The build starts in March so everything works before you open. These have to be true first.

- **A signed agreement.**
- **Your vendors selected and contracted** (Phase 2), one pick per system, with sandbox access to their interfaces: API, HL7, and DICOM.
- **Vendor contracts and HIPAA business associate agreements signed** before the build starts (Phase 4), and the hosting option chosen by the end of Phase 3.
- **Test access to the payers' connections** for prior authorization, FHIR and EDI, and payer enrollment and credentialing started early enough to bill at opening.
- **One named person on your side** who approves.
- **Your expected volumes and payer mix**, before payer-specific design starts.
- **Equipment delivery dates**, so the build lands on the install.

If one of these slips, the dates move with it, and the price does not. You hear about it the day it happens.